

Niobium

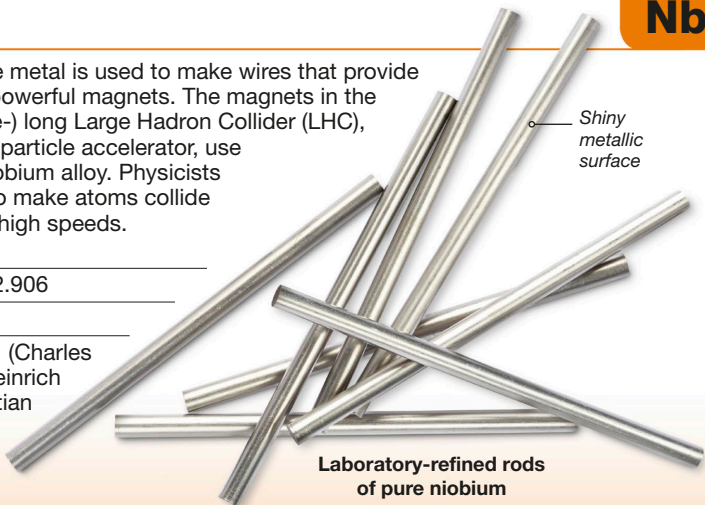
41
Nb

An alloy of this rare metal is used to make wires that provide electricity to very powerful magnets. The magnets in the 27-km- (16.78-mile-) long Large Hadron Collider (LHC), the world's largest particle accelerator, use 1,200 tonnes of niobium alloy. Physicists use this machine to make atoms collide with each other at high speeds.

ATOMIC MASS 92.906

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1801 (Charles Hatchett), 1844 (Heinrich Rose), 1864 (Christian Blomstrand)



Molybdenum

42
Mo

Molybdenite, the main mineral of molybdenum, is similar in its dark colour to galena, an ore of lead. Ancient metalworkers mistook molybdenite for galena and named it "molybdos", which is Greek for "lead". Pure molybdenum is actually much harder than lead and is used to strengthen alloys.

ATOMIC MASS 95.95

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1781 (Peter Jacob Hjelm)

Molybdenite, an ore of molybdenum

